



Review

A systematic critical review of research on ‘research use’ in education: Towards more profession-sensitive conceptualisations

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ABSTRACT

This article presents a systematic critical review of the research literature on ‘research use’ in education. The concept of research use has gradually developed with increased policy expectations that teachers should engage in externally produced research. With such expectations, it is important to ask how existing research positions the teaching profession in relation to ‘research’ and its ‘use’. The characteristics of these relations have implications for how the professional knowledge and practices of teachers are conceptualised. Based on a full-text analysis of 34 articles published in renowned databases and peer-reviewed English scholarly journals, we find that research on research use is characterised by similar problem framings and results over a 30-year period. Based on the analysis, we argue that there is a need for more profession-sensitive conceptualisations of research use in education and for more complex understandings of what it entails to employ a system perspective on research use. We argue that the next generation of studies on research use must be developed to include a conception of the teaching profession and of teachers’ professional knowledge.

1. Introduction

Education policies worldwide have emphasised the need to strengthen the use of research in schools (e.g. Burn & Mutton, 2015; Cordingley, 2015; Winch et al., 2015), which has also been echoed by researchers (Hargreaves, 1996; Ion et al., 2019; Vanderlinde & van Braak, 2010). The assumption is that research use will positively impact the development of teachers’ professional practices and, consequently, student learning. However, an increasing number of studies have concluded that teachers do not use research or use it only to a limited extent. It is increasingly clear that there is a mismatch between the intentions associated with research use and its empirical manifestation (e.g. Eriksen, 2022). This is particularly the case in settings where the research in question is produced outside of the school setting.

This dilemma has been addressed to some extent in the existing literature (e.g. Joram, 2008; Whitty & Furlong, 2017). However, few scholars have systematically examined how research use has been conceptualised and the implications of such conceptualisations for how we understand teachers’ (lack of) research use. This review provides an in-depth examination of how research use has been constituted as a phenomenon in the existing literature through an analysis of the conceptual and methodological approaches

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employed. We argue that this analysis sheds new light on the underlying challenges of research use by revealing how the choice of conceptual and methodological approaches positions the teaching profession and its relation to research use in particular ways.

Our argument is situated within a broader historical development of changing perspectives on research use. Boaz and Nutley (2019) outlined three generations of thinking on research use and evidence use in the public sector. The first generation emphasised rational-linear models, characterised by one-way processes from production (researchers) to use (policy and practice). From this perspective, research users, such as teachers, are positioned as consumers and ‘implementers’ of research rather than agentic professionals that actively shape the processes and outcomes of research use. The second generation more strongly emphasised relational approaches, often examining interactions between people in networks and partnerships as they created and used research. From this perspective, teachers are to a greater extent recognised as active agents, rather than passive implementers, in research use processes. However, the second generation also incorporated rational-linear principles of dissemination and diffusion of research results. Third-generation thinking, according to Boaz and Nutley (2019), highlights systems-wide approaches, acknowledging that diffusion and dissemination processes and relationships are shaped by and embedded in structures that mediate ongoing interactions. This so-called third generation of studies encompasses linear and relational approaches but more strongly positions knowledge as situated and context-dependent. Consequently, the role of collaboration between various actors is emphasised. The implication is that teachers’ research use must be viewed as conditioned by the systems they inhabit. This perspective also positions teachers as having important roles in the interpretation, diffusion and dissemination of research.

The historical development described by Boaz and Nutley (2019) provides us with analytical perspectives that help unpack how teachers are positioned with regard to both ‘research’ and its ‘use’. The historical trends they describe are clearly visible in research on the teaching profession. For example, over the past two decades, there has been an increase in the emphasis on collaboration and research–practice partnerships. Long-term, collaborative relationships between researchers and teachers, as well as the need to situate research use within teachers’ professional learning communities and professional development, have been emphasised (e.g. Christensen & Jerrim, 2025; Coburn & Penuel, 2016; Kirsten, 2020; Stoll et al., 2006; Vangrieken et al., 2015). However, the notion of research use in these fields often remains implicit or unexplored. This is especially the case in the literature on teachers’ professional development and teacher collaboration, which tends to focus more on contextual and experience-based knowledge than on the role of the research itself. This might be because the increased calls for research use still challenge traditional notions of teacher knowledge as primarily experience-based and contextual (Larsen, 2016). Policymakers and researchers often utilise the idea of research use to initiate professional development ‘from above’, urging professionals to make use of research and perform in ways seen as appropriate and effective with limited involvement from the profession itself (Evetts, 2003). Research use mandated from above may also lack consideration of how professional norms play a role in the use of research (Eriksen, 2022).

Much previous work has examined how conceptualisations of research use differ between policymakers and the teaching profession (e.g. Eriksen, 2022; Hordern, 2019). In this review, we foreground how *researchers* have conceptualised research use through their choice of research designs and the implications of these choices for how the teaching profession is positioned with regard to research and its use. We focus the review on studies in which education professionals are expected to integrate externally produced research with locally situated practices. As we argue, conceptualisations have not yet been developed that adequately incorporate profession-sensitive understandings of research use. With this premise as the point of departure, we ask the following research question: How is research use in education conceptualised in the existing literature, and what are the consequences of how we understand teachers’ research use? We begin by describing the methodology of the review, followed by an analysis and synthesis of the 34 included articles. We conclude by discussing the need for renewed conceptions of research use and for moving towards a fourth generation of studies on research use.

2. Methodology and methods

This critical review draws on established procedures defined in the literature on systematic reviews (Davies, 2000; Gough et al., 2012; Thomas & Pring, 2004). A critical review typically builds on an extensive review of the research but goes beyond mere descriptions of the identified articles, often with the aim of conceptual innovation (Grant & Booth, 2009). A critical review typically presents analyses and synthesises selected aspects of existing research, often challenging existing models or schools of thought while offering a new interpretation of existing research (Grant & Booth, 2009). In this review, the emphasis is on the conceptual contribution of each article, identifying and configuring elements derived from the individual articles and developing the findings from this analysis into a new conceptual understanding of research use in education (see, for example, Gough et al., 2012). The interpretative elements are thus an important driver in critical reviews, in which the contribution may then provide a ‘launch pad’ for a new phase of conceptual development (Stoll et al., 2006).

The search for articles was conducted in the Eric Education Source and Teacher Reference Center databases (all from Ebsco). An interdisciplinary database, Scopus, was also consulted to include relevant articles from other areas or articles not indexed in the subject-specific databases. The main search terms in all databases were ‘research use’ and ‘evidence use’, combined with terms such as ‘teacher’, ‘school leadership’, ‘district leadership’, ‘instructional development’, ‘school development’ and ‘organisational development’ in various combinations. Each element was built up with keywords or text words that were combined with the logical operator ‘OR’. Then, the various elements were combined with the logical operator ‘AND’. This meant that one or more words within each of these elements had to appear in the title, summary or subject words of a reference for the article to be included in the hit list. The full search syntax is included in Appendix 1. Duplicates were double-checked and removed. The full text was consulted in some cases.

The overarching inclusion criteria for the review were studies published in English; studies that took an empiric, analytical or theoretical approach to studies of *research use* (or *evidence use*) for organisational or professional development; and studies conducted

at the classroom, school and the local authority or district level in primary and secondary education. These criteria excluded studies of research use in national or state policy and studies of research use conducted in preschool or higher education. This is due to the main policy and research emphasis on research use that has been directed towards primary and secondary education. The teaching profession also constitutes a distinct professional field that differs in its contextual characteristics from early childhood education and higher education. Another inclusion criterion was that the term research should refer to research knowledge produced outside of the school setting (in contrast to, for example, research produced through teachers' action research or systematic inquiry). This is because research use is associated with particular challenges when the settings of research *production* and research *use* differ.

The inclusion and exclusion processes were divided into three phases of screening: (1) titles and keywords, (2) abstracts and (3) full-text publications. Phases 1 and 2 were conducted by a team of researchers, resulting in a double assessment of each article. Five articles that were assessed differently during the double coding were collectively discussed by the research team. During Phase 3, the final selection of articles was discussed within the research team (Gough et al., 2013). The searches resulted in 1259 articles and 871 articles after duplicates were removed. The number of articles was reduced to 54 after the titles and abstracts were screened. After the full texts of these 54 articles were read, 26 articles were excluded. The selection process resulted in 28 articles selected for inclusion following the original searches performed in 2021. Additional searches, using the same search words and same data bases, performed in 2024 resulted in 7 articles being added to the final corpus. The PRISMA flowchart in Fig. 1 summarises the search and selection process for English-language studies and provides the number of publications that were excluded in each stage.

The articles included in the review ($n = 34$) are listed in Appendix 2. The analysis was performed in two main steps. The first step involved reading the included publications and coding them in an overarching review protocol (Gough et al., 2013), resulting in an overview of the central research foci of the articles. The coding scheme was inspired by the work of Wilson (2014) and Gough et al. (2012) and previous work on systematising and analysing research in education (e.g. Prøitz, 2023; author). The coding included several descriptive variables: year of publication, country of origin of the first author, school level, actor focus, research question and aims of the study, type of study, methods used and main results. A descriptive summary is presented below.

Most of the corpus was based on studies that the researchers had collected on their own (24), with some studies either being reviews of empirical research (4) or conceptual or discussion papers (6). Most empirical studies (24) had self-reported data, either from surveys (13), interviews (4) or mixed data (7). Only a few studies included observations (3). The main actor group to be studied was teachers, followed by school leaders and administrators. Many studies had multiple actors as respondents. The empirical studies were conducted in the United Kingdom (9), the United States (4) and Canada (3). Single studies were conducted in China, Turkey, Spain, Indonesia, Australia, Greece, Sweden and Bangladesh.

To critically examine research use, the second step involved a multidimensional analysis of research use as concepts and phenomena (authors). We wanted to examine different aspects of research use, asking questions such as: How is research use defined and described? How does research use take place? How can research use be strengthened? In the first part of the analysis, we examined how the concept of research use is framed and defined, which problems research use is intended to solve, variations in how research questions are formulated and how research use as a phenomenon has been empirically studied. In the second part of this analysis, we made use of the terms *linearity or complexity* and *individualist or contextual approaches* to investigate how descriptions of 'actual use' can

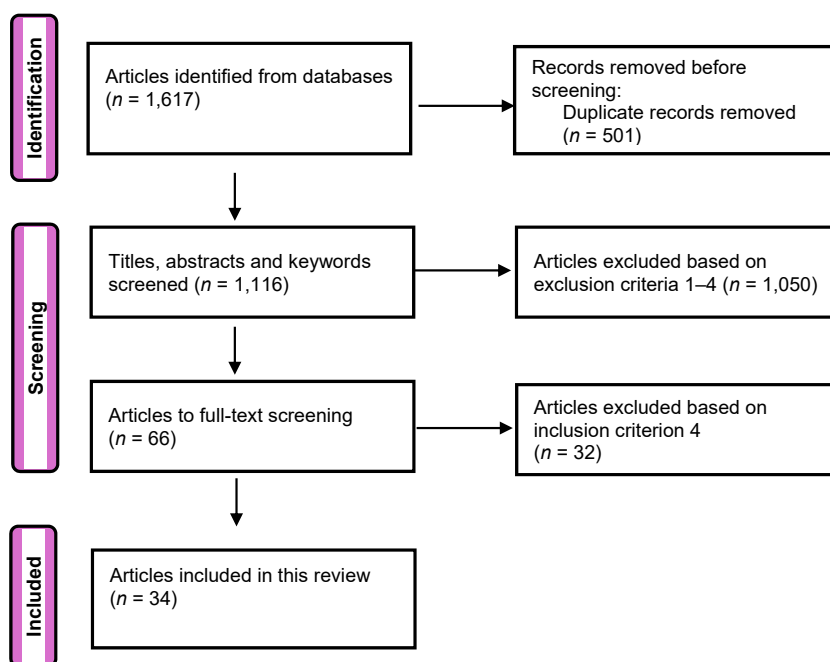


Fig. 1. Prisma flowchart of the search and selection process for the included articles.

bring more understanding to conceptualisations. The concepts of *linearity* or *complexity* refer to variations in how change is conceptualised in connection with research use. Linearity refers to a bi-directional change process from producers of research (academia) to users of research (teachers). By contrast, the notion of complexity acknowledges that change processes can be multidirectional, with teachers actively shaping research-based resources introduced to their professional practice (i.e. Boaz & Nutley, 2019). The concepts of *individualist* or *contextual* refer to the variations in whether research use is understood as an individual pursuit dependent on personal characteristics or a collective and context-dependent activity. Analysing existing research along this scale helps illuminate how different methodological approaches constitute the phenomenon of research use, depending on the units of analysis employed. Combined, the concepts of linearity or complexity and individualist or contextual help us unpack variations in how research use is conceptualised in existing research. In the third section, we focused on how the implications of the research were described. The implications are analytically interesting because they typically provide recommendations for how research use can be further developed and supported, offering further insights into how research use is constituted as a phenomenon. For example, we traced whether the implications indicated shifts in the authors' conceptualisations of research use and what assumptions of change were associated with the proposed implications. Implications are also important to analyse because they receive attention from policy-makers, practitioners and other researchers as a reference point for policy recommendations or future research.

Throughout the analysis, we systematically mapped the recurring characteristics of this body of research, examining variations in the conceptualisation of research use and how the investigation of this phenomenon has evolved (or not) over time. In the next section, we highlight three key characteristics that emerged from the analysis. First, research on research use has increased over time, but problem framing remains consistent and is characterised by deficit framing. The term deficit framing refers to the teacher profession being positioned as *lacking* in knowledge, skills or competences, which increased research use is designed to address. Second, research on research use is conceptualised and studied differently, but the results consistently show that teachers' use of research is limited. Despite methodological and conceptual variations in the included studies, the studies appear to reproduce similar findings over time. Third, research on research use increasingly highlights the need for a systems perspective. However, the arguments appear circular, that is, that conclusions (e.g. 'teachers do not use research') make up the problem framing in new studies without the actual framing being questioned. In the following section, we expand on and discuss these findings.

3. Results

3.1. The deficit framing of research use

Existing research is characterised by 'deficit framing': The stated problem is largely framed as the teaching profession *lacking* in knowledge, skills or competences. Increased research use is designed to address this problem. In this section, we demonstrate how this deficit framing of research use emerges in the included articles through a combination of problem framing (which research use is intended to solve), conceptualisations of research use and the implications outlined in the included studies.

Most articles start by alleging that research use will create better quality schools and improve student learning by strengthening teachers' professional practice and the capacity of schools to continuously develop (e.g. Brown & Zhang; Brown et al., 2016; Brown et al., 2018; Hodges, 1996; La Velle & Flores, 2018). To underscore the importance of this relationship, several authors have argued that there is a widening gap between research and professional practice (e.g. Anwaruddin & Pervin, 2015; La Velle & Flores, 2018), which prevents the generative use of research in the development of teaching and learning. Increased research use is intended to close this gap (e.g. Anwaruddin & Pervin, 2015). This idea is reflected in many operationalisations of research use. For example, Brown et al. (2018) stated that research-informed teaching 'refers to the use of research evidence by teachers in order to improve how they teach and, as a result, student learning outcomes. The use of research by teachers is considered both beneficial and desirable' (p. 36). One study linked these demands for improved results to increased expectations that teachers could legitimise their actions. Brown et al. (2016) stated that teachers 'must now demonstrate the "proof" behind their teaching and learning strategies as well as provide evidence prior to undertaking interventions' (p. 70). In turn, this was linked to the notion of a 'self-improving school-led system' (p. 71) and the capacity of teachers to learn from research.

A second problem framing is the need for improved decision-making processes, which research use is intended to facilitate. This concern is prominent in articles that empirically investigated school leadership and the use of research in district offices (Cooper, 2013; Farley-Ripple, 2012; Hemsley-Brown, 2005; Honing, 2017) but also with reference to teachers' decision-making in professional practice (Cain et al., 2019; Dagenais et al., 2012). From this perspective, research can support decision-making and, by implication, reduce some of the risks associated with addressing complex problems (Hemsley-Brown, 2005).

A third problem framing is the need for teachers to develop a new form of professionalism and strengthen their knowledge base (La Velle & Flores, 2018). As La Velle & Flores (2018) stated, 'If the knowledge bases for teachers are to move from a craft-based notion of professionalism, it is crucial that research evidence, pertinent to the practice of teaching, is made available to educators at all levels' (2018, p. 525). These notions are often clustered with terms such as improvement, outcomes and effectiveness (e.g. Brown et al., 2018). Research use is closely linked to the need for professional and organisational development.

Such formulations are typically combined with references to studies that have shown that teachers do not—or only to a limited extent—use research as part of professional practice. This combination produces what can be described as deficit framing: Professionals—primarily teachers—in education are not using enough research due to individual or systemic barriers, which in turn impedes educational development. An illustrative example can be found in Lysenko et al. (2015), who adopted deficit framing in their study of the predictors of Canadian school practitioners' ($N = 2425$) use of research. The authors argued that despite considerable efforts, the unsystematic use or non-use of educational research in professional practice still deters the progress and success of

educational development efforts.

Problem formulations associated with deficit framing have remained stable over time. For example, one of the earliest articles in our sample (Hodges, 1996) took as a point of departure that research ‘can play a significant role in improving schools and classrooms and in stimulating the use of innovating instructional practices’ (p. 225) but that teachers are not receiving sufficient opportunities for professional development to realise this potential. Eleven years later, Williams and Coles (2007a) stated that the ‘use of research evidence produced by others is seen as central to the reflective practice of schoolteachers ... but there are still concerns about the lack of engagement by teachers’ (p. 185). By 2012, Dagenais et al. noted that the ‘trend towards using research knowledge towards improving policies and practices is on the rise. However (...) it seems that school practitioners make little use of research, and it is not clear what conditions would facilitate or obstruct this use’ (p. 285). In a more recent article, Cain et al. (2019) stated that despite ‘numerous efforts to align educational practice more closely with findings from educational research, there is little clarity about how educational practitioners can, in principle, use research’ (p. 1072). These examples illustrate that the point of departure for research on teachers’ research use has remained quite stable for more than 20 years.

To summarise, a main finding is that the problem framing in existing research has remained relatively consistent over time and has been largely characterised by deficit framing, in which the teaching profession is perceived as lacking specific characteristics. This framing also informs how research use is empirically investigated in existing research, as we examine in more depth in the following section.

3.2. Methodological variation with similar conclusions

Another characteristic of the included studies is that they tended to reproduce the same findings despite methodological and conceptual variations. As outlined in the previous section, the problem framing that characterises much of the literature can be summarised as follows: Research use is a good thing, but teachers are not using research, and we are not sure why. This framing appears quite consistent. However, there remains considerable diversity in how the phenomenon of research use is operationalised. In this section, we discuss this diversity by examining nuances in the conceptualisations of research use and its relation to different aspects of teachers’ professional practice. We also illustrate that this diversity tends to reproduce similar conclusions.

The analytical distinction between *linearity* and *complexity* is useful for unpacking the conceptualisations of research use. One group of studies within our sample predominantly adopted a linear understanding of research use. This approach sequences the relationship between research and professional practice as one in which teachers first acquaint themselves with relevant research and subsequently implement insights from research in their classrooms, positioning teachers as receivers and implementers of knowledge that others produce. For example, Brown et al. (2018) defined research-informed teaching practice as ‘the use of research evidence by teachers in order to improve how they teach and, as a result, student learning outcomes’ (p. 35), and Anwaruddin and Pervin (2015) conceptualised engagement with research as reading research-based literature and systematically using these texts for professional development. Studies reflecting linear understandings of research use tend not to pay much attention to how insights from research are ‘translated’ into teachers’ professional practice or to how teachers interpret, modify or contextualise research-based knowledge. The key problem addressed within this body of research is whether teachers have access to and engage in research at all. This problem of research uptake is often connected to the characteristics of teachers. Examples of such characteristics include their lack of knowledge about research (Anwaruddin & Pervin, 2015) or their missing competencies, such as research literacy (Williams & Coles, 2007a). Additionally, the problem of uptake is connected to the role of school leaders or to the organisational environment of the schools, particularly regarding access to research and the time afforded to professional development.

By contrast, another group of articles within our sample adopted an understanding of research use characterised by a greater degree of complexity. These studies typically emphasise the processual, situated and complex characteristics of research use and sometimes explicitly position themselves in contrast to more rational-linear perspectives. For example, Cordingley (2008) focused on ‘the learning processes involved in the progression from reading research texts to putting them to work in classrooms’ (p. 37). A key assumption in this text is that teachers need to ‘connect intellectually, practically and emotionally with the knowledge they are offered in research accounts’ (p. 37) for research to inform professional practice. This perspective assumes that research must be actively interpreted by teachers and recontextualised in their respective contexts. It also emphasises the need for mediation and brokerage by school leaders and policymakers and for support structures that help teachers make judgements about the relevance of research for their professional practice. For example, La Velle and Flores (2018, p. 533) proposed a model for research-based knowledge enhancement of teaching that included steps that emphasised the role of ‘mediation’, ‘transformation’ and ‘reflection-in-action’. They further stressed that using research to inform professional practice is not a technical activity but ‘entails the consideration of the wide array of variables and contexts such as teachers’ knowledge, professional values and dispositions; organisational and cultural aspects of the settings in which they work and the wider social and policy environment’ (p. 533).

Other examples of this approach include Dagenais et al. (2012), who emphasised the mutually constitutive relationship between research and practitioner knowledge, defining evidence-based education as ‘the synergistic integration of the best available empirical evidence and professional wisdom in making decisions about how to deliver instruction’ (p. 286). Similarly, Borg (2010) argued that we should ‘disavow simplistic assumptions that the problem [of the lack of research use] lies exclusively with teachers, as powerful social, cultural, political and institutional factors do also contribute’ (p. 421).

More generally, these studies typically emphasised the interactions between research and practitioners or between research use and professional practice, with analytical attention directed at unpacking and problematising these relations in more explicit ways than studies adopting a more linear conceptualisation. These conceptualisations have also highlighted how the interrelationship between practices of research use and professional practices is multi-directional and informed by cultural, social and political factors.

We now turn to our second conceptual distinction between individualist and contextual conceptualisations of research use. This conceptual pair allows us to distinguish between studies that are based on methodological individualism and studies that regard research use as a situated and contextually informed activity. In the first group of studies, research use as a phenomenon is primarily constituted through an analytical focus on the perceptions, attitudes or actions of individual teachers or school leaders. This becomes visible, for example, through an analytical focus on teachers' information literacy (Williams & Coles, 2007) or educational practitioners' attitudes and motivations towards research use (e.g. Brown & Zhang, 2016). From this perspective, efforts to strengthen research use often emphasise the development of individual competencies, attitudes or dispositions. For example, Brown and Zhang (2016) asked whether teachers' engagement with evidence-informed behaviour is rational. Their point of departure was that if such engagement was rational, the teachers would be doing it. They highlighted that much of the literature within the field will argue that 'because EIP [evidence-informed practice] has beneficial outcomes, engaging in EIP [evidence-informed practice] "makes sense"' (p. 784). This theoretical and methodological approach situates teachers' research use within a paradigm of methodological individualism that analytically foregrounds the attitudes and behaviours of individuals. Consequently, both problem framings and proposed solutions are, to a great extent, directed at the individual as the main unit of analysis.

By contrast, studies that adopt a more contextual approach typically situate research use within a broader social, organisational and epistemic context. Analytical attention is directed at how specific characteristics of these contexts support or discourage research use (e.g. Borg, 2010; Brown et al., 2016; Cordingley, 2008; Dagenais et al., 2012; Farley-Ripple, 2012; Hemsley-Brown, 2005; La Velle & Flores, 2018; Rickinson et al., 2022; Schaik et al., 2018). These contextual factors may include leadership support, organisational routines, social interactions between teachers or knowledge infrastructures that provide teachers with access to research. From this perspective, efforts to strengthen research use may emphasise the necessity of trust among teachers at a given school (Brown et al., 2016), the need for organisational routines and epistemic resources to support research use (Farley-Ripple, 2012; Schaik et al., 2018) or the need for collective processes at the school level that are facilitated by school leaders. One example is the work of Dagenais et al. (2012), who conceptualised research use as a 'multifaceted, multidimensional construct' (p. 287). They analytically mobilised a range of factors that may influence research use and operate at different levels of analysis. This analytical approach combines multiple units of analysis and aims to unpack some of the interrelationships between them. As a result, research use is conceptualised as a highly complex phenomenon, and its realisation depends on a range of contextual and individual variables.

The analytical distinction between individualist and contextual dimensions of research use is not necessarily clear-cut at the level of individual articles. For example, an article may rely on research methodologies that foreground individual characteristics but still emphasise the role of contextual factors when discussing the implications of their findings (e.g. Brown & Zhang, 2016; Lysenko, 2015). However, this distinction is analytically beneficial for exploring the possible implications of different conceptualisations of research use. If the 'problem' of a lack of research use is constituted through an analytical focus on an individual's actions, attitudes or preferences, then the 'solution' is likely to be focused on behavioural or attitudinal change among teachers or school leaders. In contrast, if a problem definition encompasses the organisational and epistemic environment of teachers or recognises the interactional dynamics between teachers and representations of research, then recommendations for further development are more likely to take a broader range of contextual factors into account.

The fact that a given phenomenon is described through a variety of conceptualisations is not surprising. This variety of conceptualisations sheds light on the phenomenon of research use from multiple perspectives, adding nuance to our understanding of research use. This variety also reflects the different generations of research outlined in the introduction. It is striking, however, that despite considerable methodological and conceptual variety, problem formulations and findings remain quite constant over time—that is, most empirical studies have concluded that teachers do not engage in research to a great extent. For example, Williams and Coles (2007a) concluded that their survey respondents were 'positively motivated towards the use of research evidence' but that 'their actual use of research information was limited' (p. 185). Cooper (2013) stated that, despite growing awareness of research use and the increased presence of support structures, 'actual research use remains modest' (p. 1). Lysenko et al. (2015) reported that research use among their respondents was 'infrequent' (p. 35); moreover, Proctor (2015) reported a 'consistent gap between how much teachers value the use of research and how much they use research in their daily practices' (p. 464). In short, the significant methodological and conceptual variety does not seem to bring us out of a pattern in which problem formulations and findings are repeated across time and with different research designs.

3.3. *Circularity in research on research use*

A third characteristic of the included articles concerns how the implications for future practice, research and policy are described in the literature. We decided to analyse the implications because of the patterns described in the previous two sections. If problem formulations and findings are consistent over time, will there be variations in what future actions are suggested by researchers? The implications sections are also important to critically analyse because they are often afforded attention by policymakers, practitioners and other researchers. A key finding is that the implications sections tend to emphasise more of the same, with some variations. On the one hand, recommendations for system-level changes to enhance research use have increased over time. On the other hand, very few studies suggest a renewal of the conceptualisations of research use or of how it should be studied.

The articles suggest a variety of implications to better facilitate 'research use', involving a broad range of actors: individual teachers, teachers as a collective group, school leaders, school districts, researchers and teacher educators. The objects of change included teachers' cognitive structures and individual capacities, professional development initiatives at the school level, leadership practices and research content.

In some articles, we found a direct relationship between how research use is defined and what kinds of solutions or implications are

suggested. For example, the empirical analysis may be situated at the level of individual teachers or leaders, while multilevel implications are suggested (e.g. Hemsley-Brown, 2005). This is not in itself surprising, given that the implications will typically be focused on the 'enabling factors' for the involved actors. A third variety is that a process of reductionism occurs between conceptualisations and framing, results and elaborations on implications. This implies that a study with a rather complex conceptualisation of research use can emphasise more singular and instrumental solutions as implications (see Schaik et al., 2018).

A few authors have called for more agentic positions for teachers in this body of research, for example, Brown et al. (2018): 'The findings, however, have identified the teachers themselves as key drivers in the development to enhance research use in schools, recognising that an agentic position of the profession is necessary' (Brown et al., 2018). Moreover, Brown et al. (2018) linked this more agentic position to an increased emphasis on systems approaches, including strengthening networks and social ties. Such calls also acknowledge that teachers' knowledge base is complex and multifaceted, thereby reinforcing the need for teacher agency (e.g. Schaik et al., 2018). However, a general finding is that teachers' agency is rarely explicitly discussed in the implications section of the included articles.

Calls for other methodological designs to study research use were made in a few articles. One example is Cain et al. (2019), who highlighted the need for more observation studies to capture the micro-interactions of research use: 'It is necessary to attend to the minutiae of everyday teaching interactions and to the decisions that underpin such interactions, and to the channels of communication that allow ideas to be introduced, challenged, refined and adopted' (Cain et al., 2019). These calls do not fundamentally challenge existing conceptualisations of research use but highlight the lack of certain forms of data in existing research.

A key characteristic emerging from our analysis is that the implications formulated in the articles appear to be fairly constant over time, with some variations in lists of factors that are important for improving research use. An example of such implications is as follows: 'The findings show that teachers are more likely to be willing to engage with research and use it to explore and inform their practice when it is accessible – physically, conceptually, linguistically and practically – credible, useable and interesting' (Borg, 2010). These factors have been identified in numerous articles and are often accompanied by highlighting the role of system factors and leadership at the school and district levels (e.g. Honig, 2017; LaPointe-McEwan, De Luca & Klinger, 2017). The following is an example from Brown and Zhang:

These factors are: 1) the existence of teacher capacity (that is, ability) to engage in and with research and data; 2) school cultures that are attuned to evidence use (that is, that make research-use a cultural norm); 3) schools promoting the use of research as part of an effective learning environment; and 4) the existence of effective structures, system and resource that facilitate research-use and the sharing of best practice (Brown & Zhang, 2018, p. 384).

Studies that have more specifically investigated the role of educational leaders argue that these actors also lack the competence and knowledge needed to support teachers' research use. LaPointe-McEwan et al. stated in their implications section:

Due to low levels of research literacy and limited time, participants do not fully interrogate the reliability, empirical basis or validity of this evidence. Rather, middle leaders and teachers readily use the evidence provided by experts to shape their inquiry focus (...) Participants in our study were unlikely to question the presented evidence or to use additional research evidence to corroborate their own experiences or help analyse their classroom evidence, suggesting that middle leaders and teachers may need intentional support to help them evaluate and use research evidence effectively (LaPointe-McEwan et al., 2017, p. 149).

This example illustrates that the 'deficit discourse' discussed previously is also reflected in the implications. This generates a sense of circularity. On the one hand, many articles take as a point of departure that research use is needed due to some form of deficit among school professionals or in professional practice. On the other hand, the implications re-confirm this lack and state that it needs to be further addressed in future research, policy or practice. Rather than asking whether established ways of reasoning about research use need renewal, the same problem framings are reproduced through the suggested implications in the articles.

In short, we summarise our findings as follows: First, the implications sections of the articles tended to emphasise 'more of the same', as illustrated by the trend that problem formulations and findings remain consistent but that the emphasis on enabling system factors increases over time. Second, we could not find many examples of implications that challenge existing conceptualisations of research use or highlight the need for alternative approaches to studying research use. As a result, this body of research appears somewhat circular in nature. Researchers have mainly kept operating within similar problem framings and produced similar findings over a period of decades, but to a limited extent, point to implications that can bring us out of this bind. As such, the implications emerging from this body of research do not seem to address underlying problems or suggestions for what possible changes can help transform the research agenda. With the same conceptualisations in use, studies of system factors will also reproduce similar findings and problem framings.

4. Discussion

We asked the following research question: How is research use in education conceptualised in the existing literature, and what are the consequences for how we understand teachers' research use? The analysis identified three main characteristics of the conceptualisations: (1) the literature on research use has increased over time, but problem framing has remained consistent and is characterised by deficit framing; (2) the literature on research use has been conceptualised and studied differently, but the results consistently show that teachers' use research is limited and (3) the literature on research use has been increasingly highlighting the need for a system perspective, but the arguments appear somewhat circular.

Our findings are limited to studies in which externally produced research is introduced to schools. This choice highlights the specific challenges posed to teachers' research use when they were asked to combine externally produced knowledge resources with locally situated teaching practices. Other bodies of literature, such as research on 'teachers as researchers', teachers' action research

and professional learning communities, have, to a greater extent, positioned teachers as active agents and producers of research from within schools. However, these studies do not address the challenges of integrating different forms of knowledge into professional practice to the same degree.

Based on our findings, we argue that research on research use should move towards a fourth generation of studies, which, to a greater extent, takes into account key characteristics of teachers' professional practice. The reviewed studies tended to position teachers as actors in need of competence that could help increase their use of research in classroom practices and, by implication, organisational development at the school level and an improvement of student learning. However, this focus on teacher competences tended not to take into consideration the complexity of the teachers' knowledge bases. Research on teachers' knowledge base is increasingly emphasising teachers' continuous efforts to integrate diverse knowledge resources as part of their everyday work (e.g. Grimen, 2008; Eriksen, 2022; author, 2024, authors, 2023). Even in studies that conceptualised research use as a complex and multidirectional phenomenon, scant analytical attention has been paid to the characteristics of knowledge integration and the demands this activity places on teachers. Rather than framing the problem as one of a teacher's competencies, an analytical focus on knowledge integration would more strongly emphasise the constraints and affordances of research knowledge as a component of professional practice. Such a perspective would more adequately account for the multifaceted nature of teachers' knowledge bases (Shulman, 1986, 2005) and the fact that research-based knowledge will always be negotiated *in relation to* other knowledge resources in the context of a specific problem of practice (Hermansen & Mausethagen, 2023).

Second, professional norms and values are rarely highlighted as mediating factors in the existing research on teachers' research use. In professional work, the use of knowledge is deeply interwoven with the norms and values of the profession (Eriksen, 2022; authors). Our analysis of problem formulations, methodological approaches and implications show that this dimension is largely lacking in examinations of research use, or as a variable that can shed light on why teachers' research use remains limited. Our analysis of the implications sections in the corpus also points to a clear distinction between the individual and system levels. An alternative entry point could be highlighting the role-based expectations that teachers face from society and within their own professional communities and the interrelationships between these broader expectations and the calls for research use. This approach would, to a greater extent, analytically highlight the professional values that are important for the teaching profession when they meet the expectations of using research (e.g. Eriksen, 2022). For example, instances of value conflict or contextual awareness may provide some explanations for research that is not 'used'. To a limited extent, these questions have been addressed in the literature. Therefore, we suggest that more profession-sensitive concepts are needed to create a deeper understanding of the empirical phenomenon of research use.

A third point relates to the circularity identified in the existing research. We argue that this consistency in problem formulations, findings and implications signals the need for a critical discussion about how we, as researchers, frame research use through our conceptualisations and research designs. If we have asked similar questions and produced similar answers over the course of three decades, does this indicate that we need to rethink the basic assumptions of our research agenda? With this article, we seek to encourage a debate around the status quo and how the scholarly community can develop problem framings and conceptual approaches that might bring us out of the current bind, creating new perspectives for interrogating and constituting research use as a phenomenon.

A next generation of studies could consider the following: (1) Take as a starting point what we know about teachers' integration of knowledge sources, where research is one such source, as a hallmark of how they solve practical problems in schools. This is important because there is extensive knowledge about professionals' integration of knowledge sources as a hallmark of their professional practice (e.g. authors; Grimen, 2008; Shulman, 1987). (2) Teachers' work is value-based and governed by professional norms, which should also play a role in guiding research use. This implies acknowledging that both research-based knowledge and professional norms and values are integral parts of teachers' knowledge bases and must be viewed as dimensions that are in continuous interaction (e.g. Eriksen, 2022). (3) Account for how there are real consequences of how we understand and conceptualise research use in research, policy and practice (e.g. Gleditsch, 2023). On this basis, we argue that renewed conceptualisations of research use should include more profession-oriented approaches than are found in the existing literature. Such developments can be a launching pad for renewed perspectives on research use, helping to challenge some underlying problems in the literature on research use.

Author statement

The first author conceived the presented idea. The first and the second author developed the methodology and the analytical concepts. All authors conducted the selection of articles and the analysis. All authors discussed the results and contributed to the final article.

Appendix A. Supplementary data

Supplementary data to this article can be found online at <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.edurev.2025.100740>.

Data availability

No data was used for the research described in the article.

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